AS PLANNED, AT 6:00 P.M. ON NOVEMBER 20 KENNEDY appeared in front of the State Department auditorium, packed to capacity, and read a statement that began with the information on Khrushchev's agreement to remove the IL-28 bombers within a thirty-day period.

"I have this afternoon instructed the Secretary of Defense to lift our naval quarantine," declared Kennedy. "The evidence to date indicates that all known offensive missile sites in Cuba have been dismantled," continued Kennedy. "The missiles and their associated equipment have been loaded on Soviet ships. And our inspection at sea of these departing ships has confirmed that the number of missiles reported by the Soviet Union as having been brought into Cuba, which closely corresponded to our information, has now been removed. In addition, the Soviet Government has stated that all nuclear weapons have been withdrawn from Cuba and no offensive weapons will be reintroduced."

Kennedy decided to drop a statement from an earlier draft withholding any formal guarantee of noninvasion of Cuba until an international inspection regime was established on the island. The president was speaking only two days before Thanksgiving, and he had good reason to end his statement on a high note. "In this week of Thanksgiving there is much for which we can be grateful as we look back to where we stood only four weeks ago." The crisis seemed to be over. Kennedy persevered. Khrushchev was in retreat.[9]

In Moscow, Nikita Khrushchev was doing his best to present what had happened in and around Cuba as his victory and that of the Soviet Union. "As a result of correspondence we wrung a statement out of the president of the USA that he also had no thought of invading," Khrushchev told the plenary session of the Central Committee, the party's supreme decision-making body, on November 23. "Then we found it possible to make a statement that in that case we also considered it possible to remove our missiles and IL-28s. Was that a concession? It was. We conceded. Was there a concession on America's part? Did they publicly give their word not to invade? They did. Then who conceded, and who did not concede?"[10]

Khrushchev was speaking to a friendly audience. His statement, "Our men fired two shots and brought down a U-2—those are our expenses, nothing more. Not bad," was met with lengthy applause, which continued